ELIMINATION PLAYS

ABOUT THE DEALS

Feel free to disagree with the bidding; remember that it is only there so as to get to a contract appropriate for some particular elimination play. In fact, the bidding is irrelevant except in Deals where the opponent's bids may influence your actions.

With both hands visible and the opening lead noted you are asked to make a Plan for each Deal. This is to get you started thinking about how you would play the hand.

There are four or five stages shown for each Deal.

You are always going to be the Declarer, playing in the South position.

ELIMINATION PLAYS SUMMARY

There are a lot of card combinations in Bridge in which you will be better off if the opponents make the first play in a suit than you would be if you must play it first. Here are three examples.

♦ K 10 3	♦ J 7 3	♦ K 10 3
♦ A J 7	♦ Q 5 2	♦ A 9 7

The first is the frequently occurring two-way finesse. If you play this yourself you have to guess which defender holds the Queen. If the defenders start the suit you automatically win all three tricks.

In the second example you'd like to win one trick, and it will be hard to do if you must start the suit. Perhaps one defender holds both the high honors and you can guess which one and lead through him. Or perhaps someone has a doubleton honor that you can deduce. But if the defenders break the suit you just play second-hand-low and can't miss winning one trick.

With the third example you have almost no chance of three tricks if you start. If they start the suit you play second-hand-low and the next defender must play an honor. You win and then finesse the other defender for the other honor, winning all three tricks when their two honors are divided.

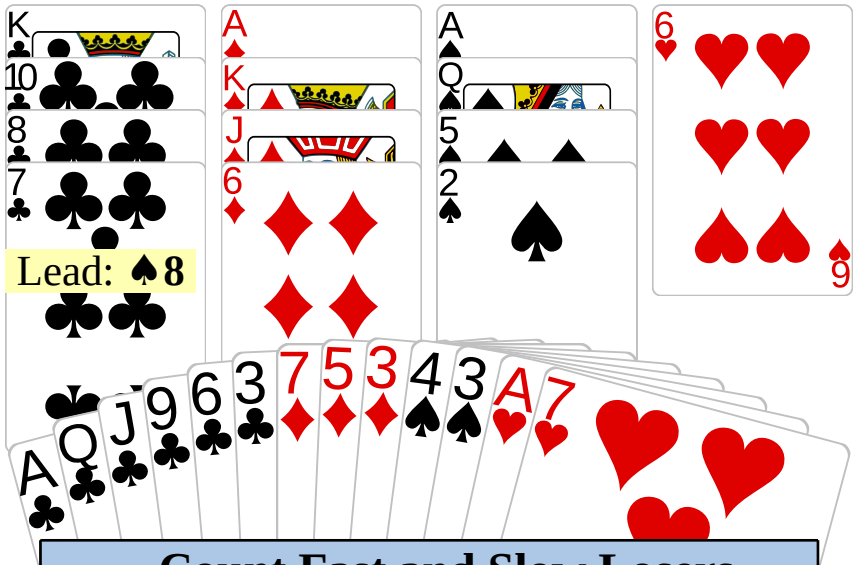
These are only three of many combinations that will benefit you if you can force the defenders to start the suit.
And that is what Elimination plays do; force the defenders to play a particular suit for you.

It works like this. You **strip** the defenders of all their "safe" exit suits, then you **throw-in** one of the defenders. If he has no safe exit, he will have to play a suit that will benefit you, perhaps one of the combinations above.

You will find that most elimination plays occur in suit contracts. This is because you can often pull all the defender's trumps while retaining at least one in both your hand and dummy. Then when the throw-in occurs the defense cannot play a suit of which you and dummy are both void because of the threat of a ruff and sluff.

25 examples are probably worth more than 1000 words.

Deal 1 Ctr: **6♣** Goal: at most ____ losers



Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Board: 1
Dealer: **West**

Contract: 6♣
Declarer: North
Lead: ♠8

Board 1
West Deals
None Vul

	♠ 4 3 ♥ A 7 ♦ 7 5 3 ♣ A Q J 9 6 3	
♠ K J 10 9 7 6 ♥ K 10 3 ♦ Q 8 2 ♣ 4	N W E S	♠ 8 ♥ Q J 9 8 5 4 2 ♦ 10 9 4 ♣ 5 2
	♠ A Q 5 2 ♥ 6 ♦ A K J 6 ♣ K 10 8 7	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
2♠	3♣	Pass	4NT[1]
Pass	5♥[2]	Pass	6♣
All Pass			

1. Blackwood
2. 2 aces

6♣ by North
Lead: ♠8

dummy's ♠Q.

A fairly complex elimination play to finish off the set.

I hope you enjoyed them.

North plays 6♣. East leads the ♠8.

You have one ♠ loser and one ♦ loser. A successful finesse will take care of either one of them. Chance of the ♠ finesse working? Zero. Chance of the ♦ finesse working? Maybe 50%. Chance of an elimination play? Priceless.

Win the ♠A and pull trumps with the ♣A and ♣Q. They split 2-1.

Play the ♦A, just in case there is a singleton ♦Q somewhere. There isn't. Then eliminate ♥s by playing ♥A and ruff a ♥.

A low ♠ from both hands. East doesn't follow suit as West wins with a small card.

West is end-played. He has no ♣s. If he plays a ♦ it will be into dummy's ♦ K J. If he plays a ♥ you will discard a ♦ from your hand and ruff in dummy. If he plays the ♠K you will ruff, and dummy's ♠Q will be promoted. If he plays a small ♠ you will let it ride to